

How I Became a Ghost Ch.4-5

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 4

Fire in the Hair

WE RETURNED FROM the river. While Luke and Jumper and I played in the backyard, Mother cooked supper. Everybody was quiet while we ate. No one said anything about the old men and women at the river. No one said anything about Treaty Talk, but the silence spoke louder than words. Soon after supper we went to bed.

It happened after midnight.

I felt no shiver. This was real.

I smelled smoke and jumped out of bed. The room was dark, but I could smell the smoke. It was behind me so I turned around. The smoke was still

behind me. I turned around again. The smoke was still behind me. I turned around and around. I was scared now.

Why couldn't I see the smoke? I wanted to scream.

I felt the skin of my neck burning. My long hair was in flames! I heard a loud *crack* and fire fell from the ceiling. I grabbed my blanket and wrapped it around my shoulders, smothering the flames.

When I opened the door, a cloud of fire hit me in the face. I ran through the flames and out the front door. My mother and father and Luke stood in the yard. Jumper was there, too. He leapt in my arms.

"We thought you ran out back," my mother said. "We called for you. The smoke was so thick."

The roof of our house was burning. Bright specks of fire floated in the night sky.

“Run next door and wake the neighbors!” my father said. “They can help us put the fire out.”

Luke and I ran to the neighbor’s house, but it was burning, too. We flung open the door and ran inside. Everybody was still sleeping.

“Wake up!” Luke shouted. With squeals and screams our neighbors jumped out of bed and fled their burning house.

“Run to the church and ring the bell!” said my father. “Wake everybody up!”

Luke and I started for the church, but my father stopped us.

“Wait! Look there.” He was pointing to the river. Men rode horses from the river, *Nahullo* men, and they carried burning torches. While we watched, they

rode to the church. They leapt from their horses and threw the torches high, aiming for the house where the missionaries lived.

We stood in the street watching, my family and our neighbors. The torches made slow circles, turning over and over, followed by a trail of sparks. Like fiery comets, twenty flaming torches fell from the sky. They landed on the roof of the house and the dry cedar boards burst into flames.

The missionaries were visiting another Choctaw town that week, but the *Nahullos* didn't know that. They would have burned the house down with the missionaries inside asleep.

A *Nahullo* man ran into the church and climbed the ladder to the bell tower. He dropped his torch on the roof and soon the church was a swirling mass of flames.

What about the Bibles? I thought. And the songbooks?

The men shouted and pointed to us. One man took his shotgun from his horse and aimed it at my family. My father threw himself over us and we fell to the ground.

Pow! The noise from the shot was loud.

“Ohhhh,” a neighbor shouted.

My face was covered in blood, the blood of our nextdoor neighbor. His shoulder was bleeding. My father took off his shirt and wrapped it around him.

“Run,” my father said, “and stay together.” We hurried to the deep woods at the end of town. The *Nahullo* men jumped on their horses and followed us.

When we entered the woods, my father pushed us into a clump of bushes. We knelt and huddled close together. My father whispered in my ear.

“Take a deep breath and do not move.” I nodded and sucked in the cold night air. Jumper climbed under my shirt. My father put his hand behind my head and pushed my face to the ground. He did this to protect me.

I lay with my face on the wet ground. A man rode his horse into the woods. He was so close. I could have reached out and touched the hoof of his horse. Even Jumper knew to be quiet. I felt him warm against my belly.

“I don’t see them!” the man yelled.

“Let them go,” said another man. “They will wander around in the swamps till we find ’em. No place else for them to go. Their homes are burning.”

“We should have done this a long time ago,” he whispered to himself, but we were close enough to hear him.

We stayed in the bushes all night and watched the houses burn. The flames made a crackling sound and by morning every house had fallen to the ground.

I learned something about houses that night. This will sound strange. On the night I almost became a ghost, I learned something about houses.

Houses are alive.

Every house shook before it fell. Like Jumper shaking water after a swim, every house shook. Every house shouted, too. As loud as the thunder, every house also shouted. One by one, every house shouted and fell.

I lay on the ground with my father, my mother, my brother Luke, and Jumper. Our neighbors crouched on the ground nearby. We watched our houses shout and shake and fall.

“I wonder if anyone burned in their house,” Luke said.

“The Jonahs,” I told him. “Mister Jonah and Missus Jonah.”

“How do you know that?” Luke asked.

I did not answer him.

My mother looked at me. Of course, she knew. She knew everything.

“There is nothing we can do,” my father said.

“We can stay together,” said my mother.



Chapter 5

Swamp Choctaws

“WE SHOULD GO NOW,” my father said. “If we wait till morning they could find us.”

We walked deeper into the woods, far away from town. We knew where we were going. For Choctaws, the safest place was the swamp. *Nahullos* never came to the swamp. We hunted there. We fished there. Whenever we wanted to be safe we always went to the swamp.

All night we walked the muddy ground. The trees were thick and covered with vines and thorny bushes grew everywhere. We arrived at the swamp as the sun was rising.

We were not alone. Every Choctaw from our town, those who were still alive, had come to the swamp. The old women were limping as they walked, and I remembered their dance on the stony river bottom.

The swamp water was green and sticky. I carried Jumper, and we crossed the swamp on logs and old wooden planks.

“Let me swim!” Jumper said.

“No,” I told him. “The water is dirty green. You can’t shake swamp water off.”

By morning, a hundred Choctaws gathered on the island in the middle of the swamp. My father led us to a thick pine tree. Old Man and Old Woman from the sandy river bottom sat at the base of the tree. Old Man stood up and everybody hushed.

“We can talk about last night later. Now we go to work. Young men will get the meat. Deer and squirrels are all around us. The swamp is full of fish.

“Young women will look for wild onions and berries. Older men will build houses, lean-tos. Winter is coming. We will spend the day working and have our first meal tonight.”

“What will the older women do?” a young man asked. Everyone grew very quiet. No one looked at him. They were too embarrassed. Old Man smiled.

“The older women do not need me to tell them what to do,” he said.

When the gathering was over, my father spoke to Luke and me. “I’ll build us a lean-to. You two see what you can catch for supper.”

I was only ten years old, but I could catch a squirrel with a blowgun. Luke and I hollowed out two long stalks of river cane. Using a sharp stone for a knife, we carved darts from tree limbs and tied bird feathers to one end.

"I think we're ready," Luke said. "Let's see if they work. You go first."

I stuck a dart in my blowgun and lifted it to my mouth. Aiming at a skinny pine tree twenty feet away, I took a deep breath and blew. The dart stuck in the tree trunk!

"Good shot," Luke said.

"See how close you can get to my dart," I challenged him.

Luke got a serious look on his face. He loaded his dart, took his breath, and blew. The dart missed the tree, didn't even come close, but I didn't fall for it. I knew Luke was a better shot than that.

"You did that on purpose," I said. Luke laughed and slapped my shoulder.

"Hoke," he said. "You're a smart little brother, Isaac. Let's go hunting."

"I've been waiting for this," Jumper said.

Jumper dashed to a clump of trees on the far end of the swamp island. Luke and I hurried after him. Jumper circled a tall pine and jumped up and down, growling and scratching the tree trunk.

"Good boy, Jumper," said Luke. We heard a scattering of leaves and the chirping of squirrels.

By suppertime we had enough squirrels to feed the family.

While we were hunting, my father and his friends had built the lean-tos. They cut pine limbs, tied the limbs together with vines, and leaned them

against the giant cypress trees. By nightfall, every Choctaw family had a home. Not real homes, not like before, but when it rained we could stay dry.

With blowguns we caught our food. With lean-tos we had a place to sleep. Young women found wild onions and leafy green vegetables, while the older women dug cooking holes. They covered the holes with green branches so the *Nahullos* couldn't see our cooking fires.

That is how we lived. A week later, winter came. Night and day we shivered from the cold wind and icy rainfall.

And every day I grew closer to being a ghost.